

SOURCES SOUGHT NOTICE / REQUEST FOR INFORMATION (RFI)

Enterprise Food Service Operations – Federal Bureau of Prisons

Notice Type: Sources Sought / Market Research

NAICS Code: 722310 – Food Service Contractors

PSC Code: S203 – Food Services

1. Description

This Sources Sought Notice / RFI is issued solely for market research purposes in accordance with FAR Part 10. It does not constitute a solicitation and does not commit the Government to issue a solicitation or award a contract. Responses will not be considered proposals and will not form the basis for award.

The Federal Bureau of Prisons (BOP) is seeking information from qualified vendors capable of providing enterprise-wide food service operations across all Bureau of Prisons-managed institutions nationwide, including optional staff dining at institution locations.

The BOP operates approximately 122 institutions nationwide.

Certain locations such as Federal Correctional Complexes (FCCs) contain multiple institutions within a shared geographic area. While infrastructure may be co-located, vendors shall assume operational requirements at the individual institution level.

For purposes of this RFI, vendors shall assume food service operations at all Bureau of Prisons-managed institutions.

Facility Types

Facilities may include, but are not limited to:

- Federal Correctional Complexes (FCCs)
- Federal Correctional Institutions (FCIs)
- Federal Detention Centers (FDCs)
- Federal Prison Camps (FPCs), including satellite camps
- Federal Medical Centers (FMCs)
- Medical Center for Federal Prisoners (MCFP)
- Federal Transfer Centers (FTCs)
- Metropolitan Correctional Centers (MCCs)
- Metropolitan Detention Centers (MDCs)
- United States Penitentiaries (USPs)

Facility types vary by mission, population, medical capability, and security level, which may impact food service operations, logistics, and staffing requirements.

The population supported is estimated at approximately 140,000 inmates within Bureau of Prisons-managed institutions.

Food service operations support this population across all institutions, equating to approximately 420,000 meals per day (based on current population levels).

Total BOP workforce is approximately 33,000 employees; however, only a subset of staff are assigned to institution locations, and even a smaller subset would have access to or utilize staff

dining. Food service operations are conducted at all institutions. Staff dining, where available, is limited to locations with established Officers' Mess facilities, and participation is variable and not guaranteed.

Operations are expected to span institutions nationwide across multiple geographic regions.

For purposes of this RFI, "enterprise-wide" refers to coordinated food service operations across all Bureau of Prisons-managed institutions nationwide, whether performed under a single contract or multiple regional contracts.

2. Scope of Services (Draft – For Information Purposes)

The Contractor shall be responsible for enterprise-wide food service operations, including procurement, purchasing, inventory management, logistics, and overall program management.

Inmate labor is expected to be utilized for cooking and food preparation functions under the supervision and control of Government personnel.

Vendors should describe their approach to operating with this Government-supervised inmate labor environment, including coordination with Government staff, quality assurance (QA), and methods for maintaining operational efficiency.

The Contractor shall provide food service management, technical oversight, QA, and training support necessary to ensure consistent execution of requirements and shall coordinate with Government personnel.

Contractor personnel must meet institutional access and background investigation requirements, which may be extensive and may impact staffing timelines, onboarding, and workforce availability. All operations shall comply with applicable security requirements within correctional environments.

Core Requirements

- Execution of standardized national menu cycle, including recipes and defined portion sizes
- Procurement, supply chain, and inventory management
- High-volume meal production and service
- Food safety, quality assurance, and compliance
- Training support and coordination with Government staff

Note

The Government retains full custody, control, and security responsibility. Contractor personnel shall have no custodial or disciplinary authority over inmates.

Menu and Diet Requirements (Summary – For Information Purposes)

The Government utilizes a standardized national menu cycle with defined portion sizes and multiple diet accommodations.

Detailed menu specifications, recipes, and portion requirements are not included in this notice but may be provided in a future solicitation or subsequent phase of the acquisition process.

Menu Complexity Summary

Meal Volume

- Approximately 420,000 meals per day
- Three meals per day, including two hot

Menu Structure

- Standardized rotating national menu
- Fixed recipes and portion sizes
- Central planning with institution-level execution

Diet Categories

- Regular
- Religious (e.g., kosher, halal)
- Medical (e.g., diabetic, low sodium, modified texture)

Planning Diet Mix

- Regular: 80–90%
- Religious: 5–10%
- Medical: 5–10%

Portion Control and Standardization

Meals are produced in accordance with standardized recipes and defined portion sizes established at the national level.

Portion control compliance is a baseline operational requirement and must be consistently executed across all institutions.

Vendors shall assume limited flexibility in portion variation and shall not base pricing on reduced serving sizes.

Detailed portion specifications may be provided in a future solicitation or subsequent phase of the acquisition process.

Production Environment

- High-volume institutional production
- Inmate labor utilized under Government supervision
- Contractor provides oversight, QA, and training

Operational Footprint

Food service operations are executed at the institution level.

Vendors shall assume decentralized meal preparation at or near each institution unless proposing an alternative production model (e.g., cook-chill or hub-and-spoke), which must be clearly described and supported.

Staff Dining (Optional / Additional Scope)

Staff dining is not required at all institutions and is only applicable at locations with established Officers' Mess facilities.

Service is anticipated to be primarily lunch, with optional breakfast and dinner depending on location and demand. Staff are required to pay for meals.

Participation is expected to be limited and variable. Vendors shall clearly identify assumptions related to staff dining utilization.

Staff dining shall be treated as a standalone optional service and shall not be used to offset or subsidize food service pricing.

No new construction or expansion is anticipated.

3. Purpose

- Identify vendors capable of supporting enterprise-wide food service operations at scale (approximately 122 institutions)
- Assess industry capability to operate in a government-supervised inmate labor environment
- Obtain Rough Order of Magnitude (ROM) pricing data to support budget planning and development of an Independent Government Cost Estimate (IGCE)
- Evaluate operational approaches, including decentralized, regional, or alternative production models
- Inform acquisition strategy, including: single vs. multiple awards and national vs. regional structuring
- Appropriate pricing models (e.g., per meal, per inmate/day, hybrid)
- Identify key cost drivers, risks, and constraints associated with enterprise-scale food service operations

4. Requested Information

Company Information

- Legal name, UEI number, and business size status
- Socioeconomic status (if applicable)

Relevant Experience (Past 5 Years)

Demonstrate experience with:

- Large-scale, multi-site food service operations
- High-volume meal production environments
- Experience in correctional or similarly controlled environments (if applicable)
- Scope, scale (locations, population, meals/day), and contract value

Capability

- Ability to support nationwide or regional operations
- Supply chain, sourcing, and distribution approach
- Experience executing standardized menus at scale
- Food safety, quality assurance, and compliance programs
- Approach to operating within a Government-supervised inmate labor model

Operational Approach (Highly Encouraged)

Describe:

- Food production model (decentralized, centralized, hybrid)
- Execution of standardized menu and defined portion sizes
- Oversight, training, and quality assurance approach
- Staffing model (recognizing Government custodial control)
- Technology or process efficiencies

5. Cost Estimate Information (ROM)

Vendors shall base Rough Order of Magnitude (ROM) estimates on full coverage of all Bureau of Prisons-managed institutions (approximately 122 institutions), unless otherwise stated.

Provide high-level, non-binding estimates.

For consistency, vendors shall assume three meals per day per inmate unless otherwise stated.

Vendors shall clearly identify all assumptions used in developing ROM estimates. The Government reserves the right to normalize responses to account for differences in assumptions to enable comparative analysis.

Provide Estimated Annual Costs For:

- Inmate food services (~420,000 meals per day)
- Optional staff dining
- Combined total

Pricing Metrics

- Cost per meal

Staff Dining Pricing

- Full cost per staff meal
- Participation assumptions

Key Assumptions

- Inmate labor utilization (Government-supervised)
- Production model
- Supply chain
- Diet mix
- Staff participation
- Adherence to defined portion sizes and standardized recipes

Cost Drivers

- Food/commodity pricing
- Logistics
- Labor (oversight/training)
- Facility variability

6. Cost/Pricing Scenario (Required for Comparative Analysis)

Scenario Basis

- 100,000 inmates

Meals (One Day)

- Breakfast: eggs, oatmeal, bread, fresh fruit, fresh milk
- Lunch: chicken, starch, vegetables, bread, beverage
- Dinner: ground beef entrée, starch, vegetable, bread, beverage

Diet Mix

- 85% regular
- 10% religious
- 5% medical

Operational Assumptions

- Inmate labor utilized under Government supervision
- Contractor provides procurement, logistics, oversight
- High-volume production
- Standardized portion sizes apply to all meals

Vendor Response

- Total daily cost
- Cost per meal
- Key cost drivers
- Assumptions
- Optional sensitivity analysis

7. Industry Feedback

The Government welcomes feedback from industry regarding:

- Feasibility and best practices for contractor-supported food service operations utilizing Government-provided inmate labor
- Challenges associated with procurement, supply chain management, and execution of a standardized national menu across multiple institutions
- Operational risks related to high-volume meal production, staffing constraints, and facility-level variability
- Considerations for training, quality assurance, and maintaining consistency across institutions
- Impacts of background investigation requirements on staffing and workforce availability
- Recommended contract structure (e.g., single award vs. multiple awards; regional vs. national approach)
- Scalability, surge capability, and transition/implementation considerations
- Cost drivers, pricing considerations, and opportunities for efficiencies

8. Submission Instructions

Responses are due no later than 12:00 PM CDT May 14, 2026.

Submit via email to: BOP-ADM-MarketResearchResponse@bop.gov

Subject Line: Sources Sought / RFI Response – BOP Enterprise Food Service Operations

Limit responses to 10–15 pages or fewer (excluding attachments). Only high-level ROM estimates and assumptions are requested at this time.

9. Disclaimer

This notice is for market research and planning purposes only. It does not obligate the Government to award a contract or reimburse any costs. Cost estimates are non-binding.

10. Reference Information

General information on BOP institutions: <https://www.bop.gov>